the time was right to strike. Athirai did not admit that the target was Rajiv Gandhi at that stage of her interrogation. The place Kanagasabapathy chose was:

> [A two-room] Central-government quarter, illegally rented out by its government servant, had made it the perfect cover. It was located in a sprawl of single-storey government accommodation in north Moti Bagh in south Delhi. It was just eight kilometres away from Rajiv Gandhi's 10 Janpath residence. Kanagasabapathy had paid Rs 5000 as advance to the broker, claiming his granddaughter would come and stay there very soon to study Hindi and computers.[1]

Jayakumar was brought back into the interrogation with Athirai and Kanagasabapathy. He confirmed that while Sivarasan was confident of accomplishing the task of killing Rajiv Gandhi in Tamil Nadu, his immediate boss Pottu Amman preferred the Indian capital. 'Why don't we try Delhi?' Pottu Amman had asked in a coded message in March 1991. 'I am confident that I can do it here [in Tamil Nadu],' Sivarasan had replied in a coded message. Pottu Amman had insisted he continue with Delhi as the backup plan. The Delhi plot was, naturally, abandoned after the LTTE's success in Sriperumbudur.

Sivarasan's stories had made him an almost cult figure in the eyes of the investigators. He was proving to be too smart for the sleuths. The best and worst part was that the more the interrogators heard about the one-eyed mastermind, the more mesmerized they got.

Jayakumar further claimed that Sivarasan, not getting any help from Jaffna despite repeated calls for a boat, sent Athirai and Kanagasabapathy off to Delhi to escape through Nepal. If that would have been a success, he, too, would take the same route out of the country. Thyagarajan was all set for that.

Verma asked Kanth to join the interrogation at that point, since it was he who had arrested Kanagasabapathy and Athirai from a hotel in Paharganj in